

2144. Minimum Cost of Buying Candies With Discount

Difficulty: Easy

Link: <https://leetcode.com/problems/minimum-cost-of-buying-candies-with-discount/?envType=daily-question&envId=2026-06-01>

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Problem:

A shop is selling candies at a discount. For **every two** candies sold, the shop gives a **third** candy for **free**.

The customer can choose **any** candy to take away for free as long as the cost of the chosen candy is less than or equal to the **minimum** cost of the two candies bought.

- For example, if there are 4 candies with costs 1, 2, 3, and 4, and the customer buys candies with costs 2 and 3, they can take the candy with cost 1 for free, but not the candy with cost 4.

Given a **0-indexed** integer array `cost`, where `cost[i]` denotes the cost of the i^{th} candy, return *the minimum cost of buying all the candies*.

Example 1:

Input: `cost = [1,2,3]`

Output: 5

Explanation: We buy the candies with costs 2 and 3, and take the candy with cost 1 for free.

The total cost of buying all candies is $2 + 3 = 5$. This is the only way we can buy the candies.

Note that we cannot buy candies with costs 1 and 3, and then take the candy with cost 2 for free. The cost of the free candy has to be less than or equal to the minimum cost of the purchased candies.

Example 2:

Input: `cost = [6,5,7,9,2,2]`

Output: 23

Explanation: The way in which we can get the minimum cost is described below:

- Buy candies with costs 9 and 7
- Take the candy with cost 6 for free
- We buy candies with costs 5 and 2
- Take the last remaining candy with cost 2 for free

Hence, the minimum cost to buy all candies is $9 + 7 + 5 + 2 = 23$.

Example 3:

Input: `cost = [5,5]`

Output: 10

Explanation: Since there are only 2 candies, we buy both of them. There is not a third candy we can take for free.

Hence, the minimum cost to buy all candies is $5 + 5 = 10$.

Constraints:

- `1 <= cost.length <= 100`
- `1 <= cost[i] <= 100`